

06. Food Management and PDS

- Since 2020-21, under the *One Nation-One Ration Card* scheme, **inter-state portability** has benefitted a growing number of ration card holders. Beneficiaries in Uttar Pradesh rose from **8.88 Lakh in 2021-22** to **38.12 Lakh in 2024-25**, a **4.29-fold increase in three years**. In the first nine months of 2025-26, **28.03 Lakh people** were benefitted. Overall, since inception, **1.12 Crore UP ration card holders in other States** and **1.88 Lakh from other States in UP** have availed the scheme.
- The total number of **PDS shops is 78,510**, of which **22.9 percent** are allotted to women. As of 31 December 2025, the number of Antyodaya ration card holder families in the State stood at **40.85 Lakh**, which is **10.06 percent** of the estimated total **4.06 Crore families** for 2025.
- Under the multipurpose initiative of the '**Model Fair Price Shop**', up to 31 January 2026, a total of **7,481 Annapurna Bhavans** has been constructed, where along with ration distribution, **CSC services** are also being operated.
- The CPI-based inflation rate, with continuous decline after COVID, reached **(-1.71 by October 2025 in 2025-26)**, as a result of which inflation was controlled, purchasing power increased, and improvement was reflected in the demand-based economy.
- The latest published **Multidimensional Poverty (Headcount Ratio Assessment)** was **42.59 percent in 2013-14**, which rapidly declined to **17.40 percent in 2022-23**. During this period, the highest number of **5.94 Crore people in the State came out of poverty**.

6.1 Food Security System in the State

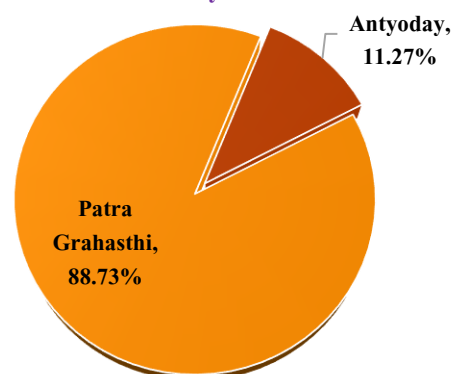
Under the National Food Security Act, the Government is committed to ensuring the availability of food grains to poor and eligible families free of cost or at subsidized rates. For this purpose, ration cards have been issued to selected eligible families, who are being benefitted through the digital Public Distribution System. In the State, as of December 2025, a total of **78,510 fair price shops** are operating, of which **67,114 are in rural areas** and **11,396 in urban areas**. By December 2025, a total of **362.35 Lakh ration cards** had been issued in the State, including **40.85 Lakh families (11.27%) under the Antyodaya category** and **321.50 Lakh families (88.73%) under the eligible household category**, all covered under the provisions of the Act.

Source- *Population Projection, Economics & Statistics Division, Uttar Pradesh. **Multidimensional Poverty in India since 2005-06, NITI Aayog.

Table 6.1: Number of Ration Card Holders in Uttar Pradesh (in Lakh)

Year	Antyodaya	Patra Grihasthi	Total
1	2	3	4
2018-19	40.94	319.47	360.41
2019-20	40.94	312.04	352.98
2020-21	40.94	318.51	359.45
2021-22	40.94	320.75	361.69
2022-23	40.91	320.07	360.98
2023-24	40.91	319.87	360.78
2024-25	40.89	316.33	357.22
2025-26 (31 Dec 2025)	40.85	321.50	362.35

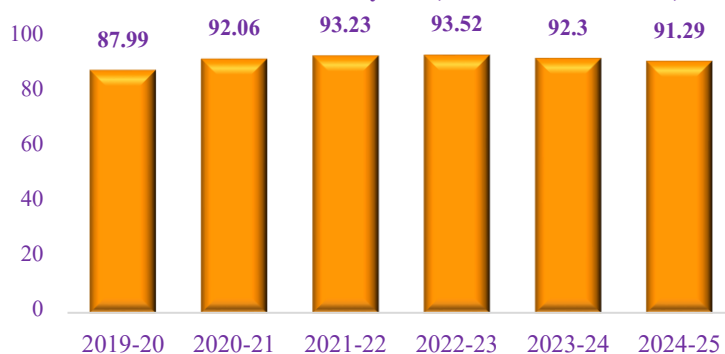
Figure 6.1: Percentage of Antyodaya and Patra Grahasthi Ration Card Holders in the year 2025-26



Source: Department of Food and Civil Supplies, Uttar Pradesh

During the COVID-19 global pandemic, the *Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana* was launched, which has been extended from 01 January 2024 for the next five years to provide free foodgrains to economically weaker families. Under the *National Food Security Act (NFSA)* in 2024-25, **96.99 Lakh metric tons** of foodgrains were allocated, against which **91.29 Lakh metric tons** were distributed to beneficiary households. In 2025-26, out of a total allocation of **73.59 Lakh metric tons**, **66.16 Lakh metric tons**, that is, **89.90%** had been distributed to targeted beneficiaries by the end of December 2025.

Figure 6.2: Distribution of Foodgrains in the State under the National Food Security Act (in Lakh metric tonnes)



Source: Department of Food and Civil Supplies, Uttar Pradesh

Expanding the Public Distribution System, the *One Nation-One Ration Card* scheme has been implemented since May 2020, enabling national portability under which ration card holders of Uttar Pradesh can obtain their entitled foodgrains from fair price shops in other states, and vice versa. In its initial year 2020-21, 0.12 Lakh beneficiaries from Uttar Pradesh availed this facility in other states. During the COVID-19 period, the scheme proved highly effective, with beneficiaries rising significantly to 8.88 Lakh in 2021-22, 13.75 Lakh in 2022-23 (a 54.8% increase over the previous year), and 23.50 Lakh in 2023-24 (a 70.9% increase). In 2024-25, 38.12 Lakh ration card holders from Uttar Pradesh accessed foodgrains in other states (a 62.2% increase), while 0.75 Lakh beneficiaries from other states received foodgrains in Uttar Pradesh; additionally, 334.05 Lakh beneficiaries availed intra-district portability and 47.25 Lakh availed inter-district portability. By

December 31, 2025, under inter-state portability in 2025-26, 28.03 Lakh ration card holders from Uttar Pradesh received foodgrains in other states, while 0.68 Lakh beneficiaries from other states accessed foodgrains in Uttar Pradesh; meanwhile, 279.22 Lakh beneficiaries utilized intra-district portability and 39.37 Lakh benefited from inter-district portability.

Through this scheme, economically weaker working families migrating to other districts or states for employment are able to receive free foodgrains at fair price shops there as well, which serves as a significant support in strengthening their livelihood.

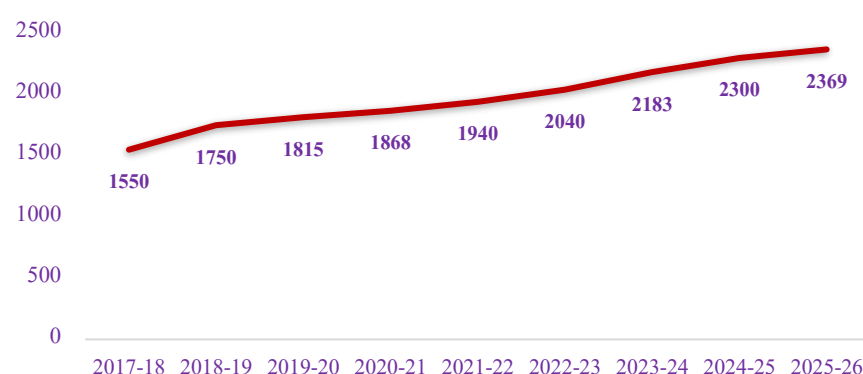
6.2 Minimum Support Price (MSP) and Procurement Status of Major Foodgrain Crops in Uttar Pradesh

An important dimension of food security is ensuring that the government's "food basket" remains adequately stocked with foodgrains. It is noteworthy that although Uttar Pradesh accounts for only about 13.5% of the country's total cropped area, the state contributes nearly 20.6% to India's total foodgrain production, thereby ranking first in the nation. Since the arrival of crops in each season generally leads to a decline in their prices in open markets, the government protects farmers from potential losses by fixing Minimum Support Prices (MSP) and undertaking procurement of their produce.

In the Rabi marketing year 2017-18, the Minimum Support Price (MSP) for wheat was Rs. 1,625 per quintal, which by 2025-26 (the ninth year) had increased by 49.23% to Rs. 2,425 per quintal. In 2017-18, 8.00 Lakh farmers benefited, whereas in 2025-26 procurement of 10.27 Lakh metric tons of wheat ensured farmer benefits. Data from 2024-25 and 2025-26 clearly show that, since wheat prices in open markets remained higher, farmers received returns above MSP. Thus, the objective of MSP to guarantee fair value and protect farmers from losses was effectively realized.

Similarly, in the Kharif marketing year 2017-18, the Minimum Support Price (MSP) for paddy was Rs. 1,550 per quintal, which by 2025-26 (the ninth year) had risen by 52.84% to Rs. 2,369 per quintal. During the procurement session of 2025-26, up to December 2025, a total of 37.86 Lakh metric tons of paddy was procured, benefiting 6,14,022 farmers.

Figure 6.3: Support Price of Common Paddy (Rs. per quintal)



Source - Department of Food and Civil Supplies (Marketing), Uttar Pradesh

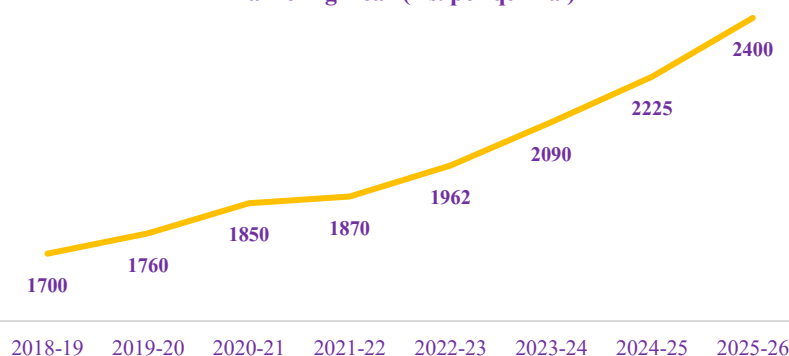
To encourage farmers' participation and promote the production of coarse grains, the government began procurement of maize at the Minimum Support Price (MSP) for the first time in the Kharif marketing year 2018-19, when 5,116.5 metric tons of maize

were procured at an MSP of Rs. 1,700 per quintal, benefiting 1,339 farmers with payments totaling Rs. 869.80 Lakh. In 2024-25, for the first time under the Rabi crop marketing session, 19,311.92 metric tons of maize were procured, with payments of Rs. 43.35 Crore made to 3,315 farmers. Thus, by continuously incentivizing farmers, the government raised the MSP of maize by 41.18% over eight years (2018-19 to 2025-26). In the procurement session of 2025-26, up to December 2025, 13,208.90 metric tons of maize were procured, benefiting 3,445 farmers with payments amounting to Rs. 3,125.70 Lakh.

In Uttar Pradesh, procurement of coarse grains (*Shri Anna*) at Minimum Support Price (MSP) began with bajra in the Kharif marketing year 2022-23 and with jowar in 2023-24. Accordingly, in 2022-23, 43.44 thousand metric tons of bajra were procured at an MSP

of Rs. 2,350 per quintal, while in 2023-24, 13.34 thousand metric tons of jowar were procured at MSP rates of Rs. 3,180 per quintal for the hybrid variety and Rs. 3,225 per quintal for the Maldandi variety. In 2024-25, bajra procurement rose 2.33 times compared to its initial year, reaching 101.31 thousand metric tons at an MSP of Rs. 2,625 per quintal. Similarly, jowar procurement increased

Figure 6.4: Minimum Support Price of Maize in the Kharif Marketing Year (Rs. per quintal)



Source: Food & Civil Supplies (Marketing) Department, Uttar Pradesh

Nutrition Security Initiative in Uttar Pradesh through Fortified Rice

Since August 2023, fortified rice has been distributed across all districts of Uttar Pradesh under the NFSA and other welfare schemes. This fortified rice is enriched with essential nutrients such as Vitamin B12, folic acid, and iron. To ensure quality supply to the public, a three-tier quality control system has been established: first, testing of premix against FRK standards; second, verification through FSSAI-notified laboratories; and third, inspection by technical staff of the Food Corporation of India at the time of distribution. In the procurement session 2023-24, a total of 36.28 Lakh metric tonnes of fortified rice was delivered to the central pool, which increased to 39.00 Lakh metric tonnes in 2024-25, representing a 7.5% rise in one year. In 2025-26, up to December, 10.88 Lakh metric tonnes of fortified rice have been supplied to the central pool.

Under the pilot project, following the distribution of fortified rice in Chandauli district, an evaluation was conducted through the World Food Programme (WFP). The results were significant, showing a marked reduction in the prevalence of anaemia among these demographic groups, with baseline data from 2021 compared to endline data from 2023.

- ✓ Among children aged 6-59 months, prevalence declined from **65.7% to 58.2%**, showing a **7.5 percentage point reduction**.
- ✓ Among women aged 15-49 years, prevalence decreased from **48.7% to 40.7%**, reflecting an **8-percentage point reduction**.
- ✓ Among men aged 15-49 years, prevalence fell from **32.9% to 28.3%**, indicating a **4.6 percentage point reduction**.



3.52 times compared to its initial year, reaching 47.02 thousand metric tons in 2024-25 at MSP rates of Rs. 3,371 per quintal for the hybrid variety and Rs. 3,421 per quintal for the Maldandi variety.

In the year 2025-26, up to December, procurement of jowar amounted to 43.56 thousand metric tons at MSP rates of Rs. 3,699 per quintal for the hybrid variety and Rs. 3,749 per quintal for the Maldandi variety benefiting 13,454 farmers through payments of Rs. 158.94 Crore. Compared to 2024-25, the number of farmers benefited increased by 25.37%. During the same period in 2025-26, bajra procurement reached 213.97 thousand metric tons at an MSP of Rs. 2,775 per quintal, benefiting 54,253 farmers with payments of Rs. 591.32 Crore. This represented 2.11 times higher procurement, 2.2 times higher payments, and 2.9 times more farmers benefited compared to 2024-25. This achievement reflects the impact of the International Year of Millets 2023 and the government's continued commitment to encouraging farmers in the production of coarse grains.

Thus, the successive increase in Minimum Support Prices (MSP) has led to relative improvement in open market prices, underscoring the government's effective efforts to ensure farmers receive fair value for their crops. It also reflects the government's commitment to making agriculture remunerative and strengthening food security.

6.3 Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana: Smokeless Fuel in Every Kitchen- Illuminating Happiness Among Women

The government has fulfilled its commitment to provide clean fuel to poor families by implementing this welfare scheme. Under the Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana, free gas connections are being provided in the name of the woman of the household. Each beneficiary of the scheme receives LPG cylinders at Rs. 840 per cylinder, against which a subsidy of Rs. 335.19 is directly credited to their bank account.

In addition, two free cylinder refills are provided every year with the objective of promoting the use of LPG and fostering the habit of adopting clean fuel. Under the scheme, in the first phase of 2024-25 (from October 1, 2024 to December 31, 2024), 88.60 Lakh beneficiaries received free refill cylinders, while in the second phase (from January 1, 2025 to March 31, 2025), 90.36 Lakh beneficiaries were covered. In the first phase of 2025-26 (from October 1, 2025 to December 31, 2025), 89.44 Lakh beneficiaries received free refill cylinders.

Since the commencement of the scheme in the year 2018-19, 185 Lakh Ujjwala gas connections have been provided so far. This scheme has proved to be a milestone from the point of view of the health and convenience of targeted eligible families, especially rural women. Through this scheme, while the social dignity of women has increased, there has also been a rise in the use of clean fuel among women, and the availability of smoke-free kitchens has relieved them from the harmful effects on their health.

6.4 Women's Empowerment through the Public Distribution System

Recognizing the vital role of women in food management, the state government has instituted a system whereby the woman of the household is considered the head of the family, and ration cards are issued in her name. In addition, priority is given to women's self-help groups in the allocation of Public Distribution System (PDS) shops. This decision marks a significant step toward women's empowerment, enabling them to become self-reliant and fostering entrepreneurship. As of December

31, 2025, a total of 4,020 fair price shops has been allotted to women's self-help groups, including 3,979 in rural areas and 41 in urban areas. Across the state, 18,032 women dealers have been engaged, of whom 22.3% are members of self-help groups. This initiative has brought about social transformation by enhancing women's experience in business management, property ownership, and employment generation, while also strengthening their decision-making capacity, mobility, social networks, and self-confidence.

6.5 Transparency in PDS through Electronic Point-of-Sale Machines

- ❁ **Digitization of PDS-** For the digitization of the Public Distribution System, the Government of Uttar Pradesh has technologically upgraded the foodgrain distribution mechanism by introducing Aadhaar-linked biometric systems equipped with fingerprint and iris scanners, along with newly developed e-PoS machines integrated with e-weighing scales. This ensures that beneficiaries receive their full entitlement of foodgrains, while the distributed quantity is instantly displayed on the official website, facilitating effective online monitoring. Additionally, SMS acknowledgements are sent to beneficiaries' mobile phones, providing immediate confirmation of the foodgrains received.

Annapurna Bhavan: Model Fair Price Shop as a Multipurpose Initiative

- ❁ In every district of the state, the system of *single-stage doorstep delivery* has been implemented, ensuring that foodgrains are transported directly from warehouses to ration shops. This has curtailed pilferage and black marketing while saving time and resources.
- ❁ In 2023-24, the government decided to construct 75 Annapurna Bhavans annually in each district. Each building is designed with two large halls and a 4-foot-wide veranda for beneficiaries' waiting area. One hall is used for foodgrain distribution, while the other is utilized for CSC operations and the sale of essential commodities. Construction during 2023-24 and 2024-25 was carried out under MGNREGA convergence, while for 2025-26, a separate budget allocation of Rs. 200 Crore has been made.
- ❁ From 2023-24 up to December 2025, a total of 7,481 Annapurna Bhavans has been constructed, while 5,522 are under construction.
- ❁ Model fair price shops have been integrated with broadband and CSC services under *PM-WANI*. This enables rural citizens to access local services such as income, caste, and residence certificates, as well as electricity bill payments.

- ❁ **Ration Card Holders' e-KYC-** The e-KYC of all units under active ration cards has been carried out through biometric authentication using e-PoS machines. This process has ensured an error-free ration card database and standardized beneficiary data, thereby facilitating their access to other welfare schemes. Extent of Coverage as of December 2025, out of a total of 14.62 Crore ration card units in the state, 92.3% have successfully completed e-KYC.
- ❁ **Alternative Essential Services through e-PoS Machines-** In the future, fair price dealers are being offered the option to implement additional computerized services that can enhance their income. At the same time, these services will enable the general public to conveniently access various essential facilities at the local level itself.

❶ **Complaint Redressal Platform-** For grievance redressal, the government has established helplines, online portals, and other mechanisms. Through these systems, beneficiaries can easily register complaints related to ration distribution and other irregularities, which are then verified and resolved, thereby ensuring transparency, accountability, and timely redressal-

- ❖ Complaints related to irregularities/black marketing by fair price dealers
- ❖ Complaints related to issuance of ration cards / ineligibility
- ❖ Complaints related to adulteration at petrol pumps
- ❖ Complaints related to LPG (cooking gas) supply

Digital Platform for Farmers: A Significant Initiative

- ❶ **Online Registration and Verification of Farmers-** Farmers are being registered online on the portal of the Food and Civil Supplies Department for the sale of their produce. Through this system, the land area and agricultural produce are verified online via the Revenue Department's land records portal, thereby adopting a swift and transparent arrangement for sales. This process ensures that farmers receive the benefits of the Minimum Support Price scheme in a timely manner while also guaranteeing a transparent payment mechanism. Uttar Pradesh is the leading state in the country to implement this arrangement.
- ❶ **Integration of e Procurement Portal and Revenue Department's Land Records Portal-** The e Procurement (e Uparjan) portal and the Revenue Department's land records portal have been integrated. At procurement Centres, food grains are purchased from farmers only after Aadhaar based biometric verification through e PoS machines.
- ❶ **GPS Tracking and Monitoring of Vehicles-** An online dispatch system has been implemented to transport food grains purchased from procurement Centres and custom-milled rice to FCI depots. By linking the Food and Civil Supplies portal with the Ministry of Transport's portal, GPS tracking and monitoring of vehicles is ensured.
- ❶ **Agri stack Portal:** For the Kharif marketing year 2025-26, a system of self-verification has also been introduced on the Agri stack portal, based on the data available there and the e-investigation records.

6.6 Food Service Management in the State

Under food service management, proper storage of food grains is a primary and important dimension, enabling farmers to preserve their produce safely even during adverse weather conditions. In recent years, with the strengthening of the state's supply chain, digital systems have been adopted to ensure the swift execution of activities, thereby guaranteeing timely availability of food grains to the public. In Uttar Pradesh, a total of 234 warehouses (152 of the State Warehousing Corporation, 48 of the Indian Warehousing Corporation and 34 of the Central Warehousing Corporation) were operational in 2017-18, which increased by 23.93% to 290 warehouses (182 of the State Warehousing Corporation, 48 of the Indian Warehousing Corporation, and 60 of the Central Warehousing Corporation) in 2024-25. The average storage capacity of warehouses in the state was 59.43 Lakh metric tons in 2017-18, which has risen by 14.49% to 68.04 Lakh metric tons in 2024-25.

Under the National Agriculture Development Scheme, out of 103 approved rural warehouses with a capacity of 100 metric tons, construction of 88 has been completed while the rest are under progress; similarly, out of 24 approved rural warehouses with a capacity of 250 metric tons, construction of 6 has been completed and the remaining are still under construction. In addition, within the PCF, out of 11 approved rural warehouses aimed at creating a capacity of 11,800 metric tons, construction of 5 has been completed while the others are in progress. Under the world's largest

grain storage scheme in the cooperative sector, the Kotwa Pandey Farmers' Service Cooperative Society in Mirzapur was selected as a pilot project, whose construction was completed in December 2023. To establish grain storage capacity of this scale in the state, 24 PACS across 17 districts have been identified for warehouse construction under the scheme.

Under food service management, the state has initiated the 'Krishak Prasar and Pest Control Service' scheme to modernize warehouses with advanced technologies and to support farmers in grain storage and protection. Under this scheme, 29,401 farmers were trained in 2021-22, which increased by 74.6% to 51,337 in 2022-23, and further rose by 184.9% to 83,781 in 2024-25. This consistent rise in farmer training reflects their growing awareness, enabling them to store their produce properly and sell it when necessary or when market prices are favourable. The warehouses have also been registered with the Warehousing Development and Regulatory Authority (WDRA).

This process ensures that when farmers properly store their produce, a negotiable warehouse receipt is issued, on the basis of which they can obtain loans from banks as needed and sell their produce later when market prices are higher. Under the supervision of the Food Corporation of India, the construction agency HLC has selected Hamirpur, Lalitpur, and Pilibhit in Uttar Pradesh for the construction of steel silos, each with a capacity of 50,000 metric tons. In these silos, food grains will remain fully protected through the automatic use of pest control measures.

6.7 Impact of Prices and Inflation

In the continuously evolving landscape of the economy, fluctuations in inflation remain a crucial factor, as inflationary pressures directly affect the general public while also creating imbalances amidst ongoing economic reforms. To address this, the central bank and the government

carefully implement inflation-control measures by cautiously relaxing their restrictive policies.

In determining the Consumer Price Index (CPI), food items play a crucial role, and therefore retail inflation is considered to be primarily driven by the Consumer Food Price Index (CFPI). In this context, an analysis has been presented of the major food items that influence inflation such as cereals and cereal products, meat and fish, eggs, milk and milk products, vegetables, pulses, sugar and confectionery, spices, etc. along with household and other essential services.

